PARMAR RAILWAY

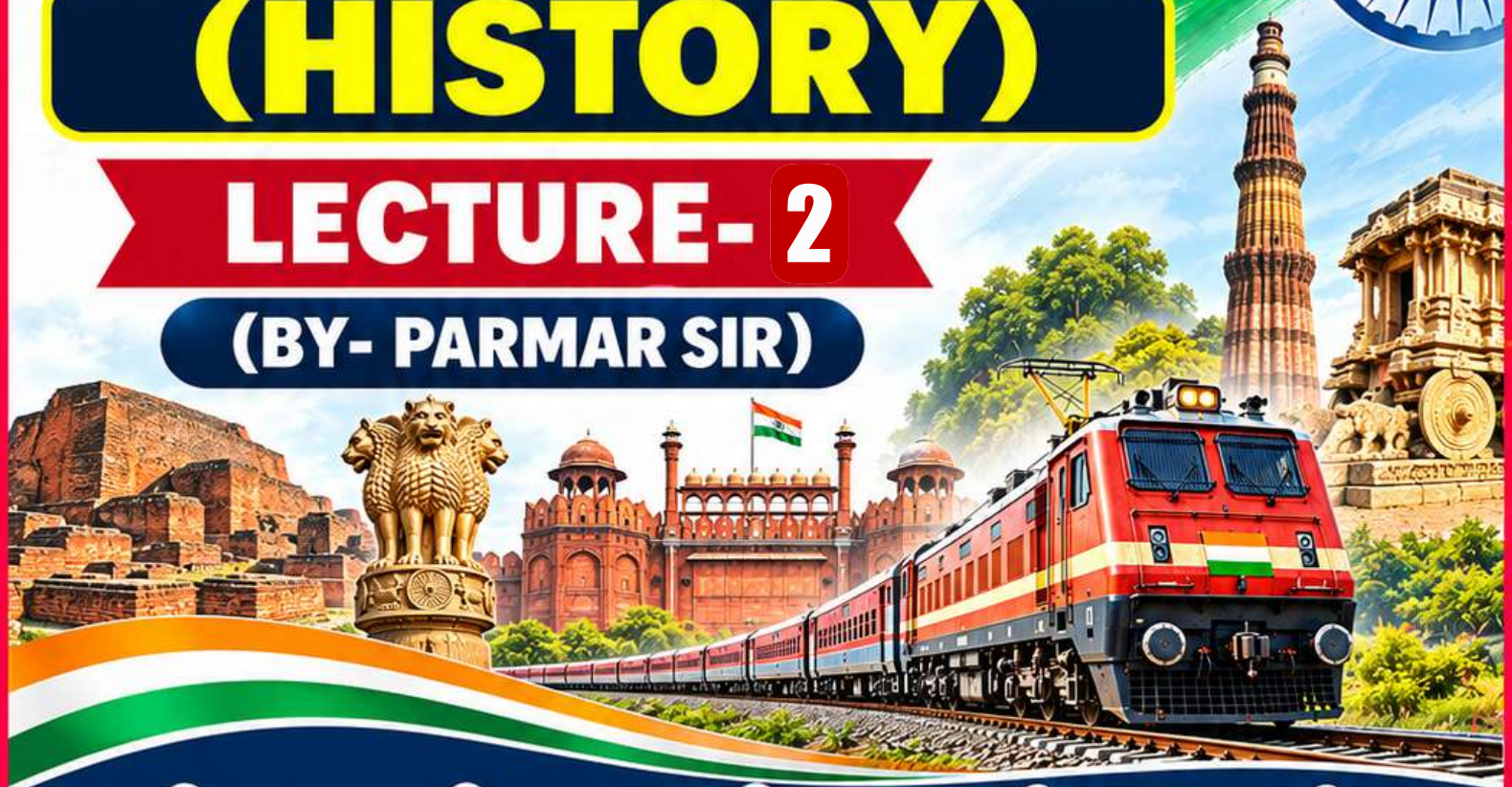
COMPLETE GK PYQ BATCH

GENERAL KNOWLEDGE

(HISTORY)

LECTURE- 2

(BY- PARMAR SIR)



ANCIENT INDIA | MEDIEVAL INDIA | MODERN INDIA | FREEDOM STRUGGLE | POST INDEPENDENCE

Q.1 At what age did Gautama Buddha attain Enlightenment (Nirvana) at Bodh Gaya in Bihar?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (28 Aug, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. 49 years
B. 42 years
C. 35 years
D. 29 years

- Buddha attained enlightenment (Nirvana) at the age of **35 years**
- Place: **Bodh Gaya (Bihar)**
- Symbol of enlightenment: **Bodhi tree**
- He left home (**Mahabhinishkramana**) at the age of **29 years**

- **Birth and family**
  - Born in **563 BCE** at **Lumbini (Nepal)**
  - Belonged to the **Shakya clan** (his father's clan)
  - Names and titles (including childhood names): **Siddhartha, Shakya Muni** (from the Shakya clan), **Tathagata**
  - Father: **Shuddhodhana**
  - Mother: **Mahamaya**
  - Foster mother / step-mother (mother's sister): **Mahaprajapati Gautami**
    - She was the first **Bhikshuni** (Buddhist nun)
  - Wife: **Yashodhara**
    - Do not confuse with Yashoda, who was the wife of Mahavira (the 24th Tirthankara of Jainism)

- **Teachers**
  - **Alara Kalama**
  - **Uddaka Ramaputta**
- **Special terms for the main events of Buddha's life**
  - Renunciation of home: **Mahabhinishkramana** (at age **29**)
    - Symbol: **horse** (he left on a horse, named **Kanthaka** or **Channa**)
  - Enlightenment: at age **35**, under the **Bodhi tree**
  - First sermon: **Dhammachakra Pravartana** (at **Sarnath**)
  - Death: **Mahaparinirvana** at **Kushinagar**
  - Short example: Buddhism has a specific term for each event, just as "impeachment" is the specific term for removing the President.
  - **Memory tip:** Buddha died at Kushinagar - he gave up his life "khushi-khushi" (happily), so "Kushi-nagar"

Q.2 Which Buddhist scripture explicitly states "All dhammas are without self," affirming the doctrine of Anatta?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (01 Sept, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Dhammapada
B. Kalpa Sutra
C. Bhagavati Sutra
D. Uttaradhyayana

- **Anatta (Anatma)** = doctrine of non-self (all dhammas are Anatma / without self)
- "All dhammas are without self" affirms **Anatta**
- **Dhammapada** is the Buddhist text that states this
- **Kalpa Sutra** and **Bhagavati Sutra** are composed in Ardhamagadhi

- **Dhammapada** has no specific author to remember

Q.3 In which of the following Buddhist literatures are the rules of conduct for the monastic life mentioned?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (09 May, 2026 (4:30 PM - 6:00 PM))]

A. Sutta Pitaka
B. Vinaya Pitaka
C. Anguttara Nikaya
D. Abhidhamma Pitaka

- **Vinaya Pitaka** = rules and codes for monks and nuns
- What rules the monks have to follow
- **Anguttara Nikaya** is not a Pitaka; it is a part of the **Sutta Pitaka**

- **Tripitaka** = Three Baskets = **Three Pali Canons**
  - Called Pali Canons because they are written in the **Pali** language
  - The three: **Sutta Pitaka, Vinaya Pitaka, Abhidhamma Pitaka**

- **What each Pitaka contains**
  - **Sutta Pitaka:** sermons of Buddha
  - **Vinaya Pitaka:** rules and codes for monks and nuns
  - **Abhidhamma Pitaka:** philosophy behind Buddha's teachings
  - **Memory tip:** remember the three as "**AP, VR, SS**" (AP like Arithmetic Progression / Geometric Progression in maths, and VR like Augmented Reality / Virtual Reality technology)
    - **Abhidhamma** – Philosophical teachings
    - **Vinaya** – Rules and codes
    - **Sutta** – Sermons

- **Sutta Pitaka** is made of **five Nikayas** (collections)
  - **Digha Nikaya:** long discourses
  - **Majjhima Nikaya:** middle-length discourses
  - **Samyutta Nikaya:** connected discourses
  - **Anguttara Nikaya:** numerical collection
  - **Khuddaka Nikaya:** minor / short collection
  - **Nikaya** = collection
- **Ananda** was one of the earliest disciples of Buddha; the sermons were given to disciples like him

Q.4 Which Buddhist text, from the 1st century BCE, records the dialogues of the Buddha?

[NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2025-26 (19 Mar, 2026 Shift 1)]

A. Jataka Tales
B. Vinaya Pitaka
C. Abhidhamma Pitaka
D. Sutta Pitaka

- "Dialogues" here means the sermons delivered by Buddha to his disciples
- **Sutta Pitaka** records these sermons

- Other options do not fit
  - **Vinaya Pitaka:** rules and codes
  - **Abhidhamma Pitaka:** philosophy behind the teachings
  - **Jataka Tales:** childhood stories or stories of previous births of Buddha

Q.5 The Abhidhamma Pitaka explores which of the following areas in depth?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (06 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Political history
B. Folk tales
C. Animal stories
D. Ethics, mental phenomena, and psychological insights

- **Abhidhamma Pitaka** gives the philosophy behind Buddha's teachings
- Covers the insights and reasoning behind what Buddha taught
- Deals with **ethics, mental phenomena and psychological insights**
- Political history, folk tales and animal stories are not its subject

Q.6 Which of the following is a Buddhist text containing stories related to the previous births of the Buddha?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (12 Aug, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Panchatantra
B. Jatakas
C. Arthashastra
D. Manusmriti

- **Jataka Tales** contain stories of the previous births of Buddha
- Other options are not Buddhist texts
  - **Panchatantra:** collection of stories written by Vishnu Sharma
  - **Arthashastra:** written by Kautilya during the Mauryan period

- **Arthashastra**
  - **Kautilya** is also known as **Vishnugupta** or **Chanakya**
  - It is not a book on economics; it is mainly a book on **politics and statecraft:** how a king should run his state

Q.7 Which of the following Buddhist texts is often called the 'Gita of Buddhism' for its importance and teachings?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (13 Aug, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Mahayana Sutra
B. Dhammapada
C. Vamsathapakasini
D. Saddharmapundarika Sutra

- **Dhammapada** is called the **Gita of Buddhism**
- It has no specific author to be remembered

Q.8 The Visuddhimagga, a key Buddhist text, was written by which of the following scholars?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (29 Aug, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Nagarjuna
B. Aryadeva
C. Buddhaghosa
D. Vasubandhu

- **Visuddhimagga** was written by **Buddhaghosa**
- **Buddhacharita** was written by **Ashvaghosha**

Q.9 'Milind Panho' is a post-Mauryan text which contains the conversations between the Indo-Greek ruler Menander and the scholar and Buddhist monk _____.

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (21 Aug, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Nagasena
B. Badarayana
C. Patanjali
D. Kapila

- **Patanjali** wrote the **Mahabhashya**
- Written in the time of **Pushyamitra Shunga** (Shunga dynasty)

- **Milinda Panho** = "Questions of Milinda"
- **Milinda (Menander)** was an Indo-Greek ruler
- He asked questions about Buddhism to the Buddhist monk **Nagasena**
- After Nagasena's answers, Milinda converted to Buddhism

Q.10 The relics of Buddha are found inside which of the following Buddhist architectures?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (19 Jun, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Rock Edicts
B. Stupas
C. Chaitya Halls
D. Ashokan Pillars

- Relics (remains) are found in **stupas**
- Examples of relics: a nail or hair of Buddha
- Relics of a **Bodhisattva** are also kept in stupas, not only those of Buddha
- A stupa represents Buddha's **Mahaparinirvana**, because his relics are kept there (just as a horse - named **Kanthaka** or **Channa** - represents his **Mahabhinishkramana** / house renunciation)
- **Chaitya** = place of worship / prayer
- **Vihara** = place of residence of Buddhist monks

- **Parts of a stupa**
  - **Anda:** hemispherical dome
  - **Toran (Torana):** gateway
  - **Medhi:** railing; the path around it is the **Pradakshina Path** (circumambulation path)
  - **Vedika:** railings (sometimes called Vedika)
  - **Harmika:** structure on top of the dome
  - **Chhatra:** umbrella above the Harmika
  - **Yashti:** pole that carries the Chhatra(s)
    - Sometimes **three** Yashtis or three Chhatras (Chhatriyas) are seen on top above the Harmika
    - They represent the **Triratna** of Buddhism: **Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha**

Q.11 Which of the following stupas marks the spot where Buddha gave his first sermon?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (24 Jun, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Amravati stupa
B. Mahabodhi stupa
C. Sanchi stupa
D. Dhamek stupa

- **Dhamek Stupa** is at Sarnath (**Varanasi**)
- Buddha gave his first sermon at **Sarnath**, in the Deer Park
- Known as **Dhammachakra Pravartana** = "Turning the Wheel of Law"
- Symbol: **wheel**
- Dhamek Stupa has a **cylindrical** shape

- **Amravati Stupa**
  - Located in **Andhra Pradesh**
  - White in colour; built using **white limestone**
- **Nirvana (Enlightenment)** (revised alongside first sermon)
  - Left home at age **29** and attained enlightenment at age **35** at **Bodh Gaya**
  - Represented by the **Bodhi tree**

Q.12 Which of the following sites is known for its paintings and sculptures, considered masterpieces of Buddhist art?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (08 May, 2026 (9:00 AM - 10:30 AM))]

A. Elephanta Caves
B. Ajanta Caves
C. Bhimbetka Caves
D. Mawsmai Cave

- **Ajanta Caves** are associated with Buddhist paintings and culture
- **Elephanta Caves**: mainly associated with **Lord Shiva**
- Most famous sculpture: **Trimurti**
- **Bhimbetka Caves**: associated with the **Stone Age**

- **Ajanta Caves** were built by the **Satavahana** and **Vakataka** dynasties
- **Bhimbetka Caves** (covered in the previous lecture)
- Associated with the **Upper Palaeolithic, Mesolithic and Neolithic periods** (mostly around the Mesolithic period)
- Located near **Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh**
- Discovered by **V. S. Wakankar**

Q.13 The artistic and architectural style evident in the Bagh Caves of Madhya Pradesh, India, is predominantly associated with which of the following faiths?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (09 Sept, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Islam
B. Hinduism
C. Buddhism
D. Jainism

- **Bagh Caves (Madhya Pradesh)** are associated with **Buddhism**

Q.14 Which of the following is NOT a principle of Jainism?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (11 Aug, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. The whole world, including stone and water, has life.
B. Rejection of the doctrine of Karma
C. Practice of non-injury to living beings
D. Monastic life is the only way to salvation.

- Jainism does not reject the doctrine of **Karma**
- The other three are Jain principles
  - The whole world, including stone and water, has life
    - Jainism holds this extreme view: even non-living things have life
  - Practice of non-injury (**Ahimsa**) to living beings
  - Monastic life is the only way to salvation (**Moksha**)

- **Triratna of Jainism** (three jewels) - **Memory tip: "KFC"**
  - **K** - Right Knowledge (**Samyak Gyan**)
  - **F** - Right Faith (**Samyak Darshan**)
  - **C** - Right Conduct (**Samyak Charitra**)
- **Five Vows (Panchavrata)**
  - **Ahimsa**: non-violence
  - **Satya**: truthfulness
  - **Asteya**: non-stealing
  - **Brahmacharya**: celibacy / purity
  - **Aparigraha**: non-attachment / non-possession (not being attached to things like a car or a person as "mine")

- **Buddhism for comparison**
  - **Triratna of Buddhism: Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha**
  - Philosophy: **Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path (Ashtangika Marga)**
  - **Four Noble Truths**
    - The world is full of sorrow
    - Desires are the root cause of sorrow
    - There is an end to suffering
    - The path to end suffering is the Eightfold Path
  - **Eightfold Path**
    - Right View
    - Right Intention
    - Right Speech
    - Right Action
    - Right Livelihood
    - Right Effort
    - Right Mindfulness / Right Thought
    - Right Concentration

Q.15 Which highly revered Svetambara Jain text describes the lives of the 24 Tirthankaras, the lineage of pontiffs, and the monastic rules observed during the Paryusana festival?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (19 Jun, 2026 (12:45 PM - 2:15 PM))]

A. Kalpa-sutradham
B. Kalpa-samant
C. Kalpa-yoga
D. Kalpa-sutra

- **Kalpa Sutra** is the revered **Shvetambara** Jain text
- **Paryushana festival**
  - Held in **August-September**
  - Lasts **8 to 10 days**
  - An important festival of Jainism
- **Bhagavati Sutra** and **Kalpa Sutra** (texts with "Sutra" in their name here) are Jain texts written in **Sanskrit**

- Jainism divided into **two sects**
  - **Shvetambara**: wear white clothes
  - **Digambara**: wear no clothes (the sky, "ambar", is their cloth)

Q.16 Which Jain text is recognised in the West and known for its verses on monk conduct, sermons, and poetic teachings?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (08 Sept, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Uttaradhyayana Sutra
B. Kalpa Sutra
C. Acaranga Sutra
D. Bhagavati Sutra

- **Acaranga Sutra** deals with the conduct and behaviour of Jain monks (and their sermons)
- It is the first of the **12 Angas**

- **12 Angas of Jainism**
  - **Angas** = "limbs", like the limbs (hands, legs) of the body
  - They are the preachings of **Mahavira** (24th Tirthankara), compiled together
  - **Acaranga Sutra:** 1st Anga
  - **Sutrakritanga:** another Anga
  - **Drishtivada:** 12th (last) Anga
  - No need to memorise all 12; remember the **first and the last**

Q.17 In Jain religion, the Svetambara canon consists of how many of Agamas?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (18 Aug, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. 6
B. 12
C. 35
D. 45

- **Shvetambara** canon has **45 Agamas**
- Do not confuse: **12 Angas** are a part of these, not the total number of Agamas

Q.18 The first systematisation of the Jain canonical literature took place at _____.

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (08 Aug, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Vallabhi
B. Pataliputra
C. Mathura
D. Lumbini

- Jainism had **two councils**
- First council: Pataliputra, around 298 BCE
  - Held in the time of / presided over under **Chandragupta Maurya**
  - The **12 Angas** were compiled at this council
- **Second council: Vallabhi, Gujarat**, around **512 CE (AD)**

- **Bodhisattva** concept belongs to **Mahayana**
  - A Bodhisattva was on the path to Nirvana (enlightenment) and about to achieve it, but gave up the path
  - Reason: to help others achieve Nirvana
  - Examples: **Padmapani** (known as Avalokiteshvara / Lokeshvara), **Vajrapani** (protector), **Manjushri**
  - **Amitabha** is also named with them as a Bodhisattva (regarded as a celestial Buddha)

- **Four Buddhist Councils** (for comparison)
  - **Places**: Rajagriha, Vaishali, Pataliputra, Kundalavana (Kashmir)
  - **Patrons**: Ajatashatru, Kalashoka, Ashoka, Kanishka (Kushana dynasty)
    - **Memory tip: "A K A K"**
  - **Chairmen**: Mahakashyapa, Sabakami, Mogaliputta Tissa, Vasumitra
    - **Memory tip: "M S M V"**
  - **Dates**
    - 1st council: **483 BCE**
    - 2nd council: **383 BCE** (100 years later)
    - 3rd council: about **250 BCE** (roughly 100 years later)
    - 4th council: **72 CE** (AD)
    - Fourth council at **Kundalavana, Kashmir**, under **Kanishka**

- Buddhism split into two sects: **Hinayana** and **Mahayana**
  - **Hinayana vs Mahayana**
    - **Idol worship**: Hinayana did not believe in idol worship; Mahayana did
    - Hinayana = **"Lesser Vehicle"**; Mahayana = **"Greater Vehicle"**
    - **Where found**
      - **Hinayana**: Sri Lanka, Thailand, Cambodia
      - **Mahayana**: China, Korea, Japan
    - **Main text**
      - **Hinayana**: Pali
      - **Mahayana**: Sanskrit

Q.19 Which of the following Jain councils was held at Vallabhi (Gujarat) in 512 CE under the chairmanship of Devardhi Kshamasramana?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (18 Aug, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Third
B. Second
C. Fourth
D. First

- Jainism had only **two councils**
- Second council: **Vallabhi, Gujarat**, 512 CE
- Chairman: **Devardhi Kshamashramana**

Q.20 Which Gumpha at Khandagiri in Odisha, India is known for carvings of twenty-four Jain Teerthankars?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (13 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Ambika Gumpha
B. Trushula Gumpha
C. Barabhuji Gumpha
D. Hathi Gumpha

- **Trishula (Trushula) Gumpha** has carvings of **24 Tirthankaras**
- **Udayagiri and Khandagiri** caves are in **Odisha**
- Built by **Kharavela**, king of the **Chedi** dynasty
- Udayagiri caves in **Madhya Pradesh** are different from these

- **Tirthankaras to remember**
  - **1st**: Rishabhanatha (Rishabhadeva); symbol: **bull**
  - **22nd**: Arishtanemi (Neminath); symbol: **conch (Shankh)**
  - **23rd**: Parshvanatha; symbol: **serpent**
  - **24th**: Mahavira Swami; symbol: **lion**
  - Only **Rishabhadeva** and **Arishtanemi** are mentioned in the **Vedas**
- **Mahavira Swami**
  - Not the founder, but the main propounder of Jainism
  - Born in **540 BCE**; died in **468 BCE**
  - Birth place: **Kundagrama, Vaishali**
  - Father: **Siddhartha** (this was also Buddha's childhood name)
  - Mother: **Trishala**, a Lichchhavi princess (belonged to the **Lichchhavi** clan)
  - Wife: **Yashoda**
  - Daughter: **Anuja Priyadarshani**
    - Her husband **Jamali** became Mahavira's first disciple
  - Enlightenment: at **Jambhika Gram**, under a **Sal tree**, near the **Rijupalika river**
  - First sermon: at **Pava**
    - If Pava is not in the options, **Rajgir** will be
  - Death: at **Pavapuri**
    - **Pava** is in **Uttar Pradesh**; **Pavapuri** is in **Bihar**; they are different places (whereas Gautama Buddha died at **Kushinagar**)

Q.21 The Mauryan empire was founded by Chandragupta Maurya in which of the following years?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (29 Aug, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. 350 BCE
B. 375 BCE
C. 300 BCE
D. 322 BCE

- **Chandragupta Maurya** founded the Mauryan dynasty in **322 BCE**
- He defeated **Dhananand**, the last ruler of the **Nanda dynasty**
- He was helped by **Kautilya** (also **Vishnugupta** or **Chanakya**), author of the **Arthashastra**

- **Nanda dynasty**
- Founder: **Mahapadmananda**
- Last ruler: **Dhananand**

Q.22 Seleucus sent his ambassador Megasthenes to the court of which Mauryan ruler at Pataliputra?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (15 Jun, 2026 (12:45 PM - 2:15 PM))]

A. Bindusara
B. Brihadratha
C. Ashoka
D. Chandragupta Maurya

- Chandragupta defeated **Seleucus Nicator**, founder of the **Seleucid** dynasty
- He also married Seleucus's daughter, named **Helena**

- **Megasthenes** was the ambassador of **Seleucus** at the court of **Chandragupta Maurya**
- Megasthenes wrote **Indica** on the Mauryan administration
- According to him, society was divided into **seven classes** (seven Varnas / divisions)
  - **Memory tip: "PCS 2 (TWO) Councillor"** (keep this exact order; here 2 = T-W-O)
    - **P**: Philosophers
    - **C**: Cultivators
    - **S**: Shepherds
    - **T**: Traders
    - **W**: Warriors / Soldiers
    - **O**: Overseers (spies)
    - Councillors: the 7th class

Q.23 Chandragupta Maurya is said to have converted to:

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (10 Jun, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Buddhism
B. Zoroastrianism
C. Jainism
D. Christianity

- A severe **famine** hit **Magadha**
- Jainism teaches extreme renunciation (giving up everything); when you give up everything, your needs become fewer
- So the burden on the state becomes lighter
- Chandragupta converted to **Jainism** under the influence of **Bhadrabahu** and went with him and some followers to **Shravanabelagola, Karnataka**
- There he gave up his life by **Sallekhana**: fasting to death, without food or water

- **Sect split in Jainism**
  - **Bhadrabahu** founded the **Digambara** sect (no clothes)
  - The group that stayed back in Magadha founded the **Shvetambara** sect (white clothes)
    - Founder: **Sthulabhadra.**

Q.24 What was Ashoka's relation to Bindusara?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (17 Jun, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Grandson
B. Son
C. Brother
D. Brother-in-law

- **Ashoka** was the son of **Bindusara**
- Bindusara was the son of **Chandragupta Maurya**

- Chandragupta adopted **Jainism**, but Bindusara adopted the **Ajivika sect**
- **Ajivika sect**
  - Founder: **Makkhali Gosala**
    - He left home (renounced house) along with **Mahavira** (the 24th Tirthankara)
  - Believes in **extreme fatalism**
    - **Fatalism = Niyati (fate)**: whatever is written in fate will happen, nothing else beyond fate

Q.25 Ashoka was the viceroy of which region under his father Bindusara's reign?

[NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2025-26 (17 Mar, 2026 Shift 3)]

A. Tosali
B. Patliputra
C. Saurashtra
D. Ujjain

- Ashoka was the viceroy of **Ujjain** under Bindusara
- He was also governor of **Takshashila**
- If Ujjain is not in the options, choose **Takshashila**

- Mauryan administration was **highly centralised**
  - Short example: like India today, a **"Federation with a strong Centre"** (a Center and different States where the Center holds more power)
- Provinces and their capitals
  - **Northern (Uttarapatha):** Takshashila
  - **Western (Avanti Rashtra):** Ujjain
  - **Eastern and Central (Central province):** Pataliputra
  - **Kalinga (Eastern):** Tosali
  - **Southern (Dakshinapatha):** Suvarnagiri
- **Pataliputra** was the capital of the central province

Q.26 Who succeeded Ashoka to the throne?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (11 Jun, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Chandragupta II
B. Bindusara
C. Samprati
D. Dasharatha

- **Caves built by Dasharatha for the Ajivika sect**
- **Nagarjuni Caves:** built by **Dasharatha**
- **Barabar Caves:** built by both **Dasharatha** and **Ashoka**
- Both are in **Jehanabad district, Bihar**

- **Dasharatha (Dasharatha Maurya)** succeeded Ashoka
- He was Ashoka's **grandson**
- **Bindusara** was Ashoka's father
- **Chandragupta II** belongs to the **Gupta** dynasty, which comes much later

Q.27 Who among the following was NOT a Mauryan ruler?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (13 Jun, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Samprati
B. Pushyamitra
C. Devavarman
D. Brihadratha

- **Pushyamitra** belonged to the **Shunga** dynasty
- He killed **Brihadratha** and founded the Shunga dynasty
- **Brihadratha** was the last Mauryan ruler

Q.28 Which of the following administrative features was a key characteristic of the Mauryan Empire under Chandragupta Maurya?

[NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2025-26 (19 Mar, 2026 Shift 3)]

A. Centralised bureaucracy guided by Arthashastra
B. Hereditary provincial governors
C. Feudal land grant system
D. Revenue collection by religious institutions

- Mauryan administration was **centralised** and guided by the **Arthashastra**
- **Arthash astra** was written by **Kautilya** (Vishnugupta / Chanakya)

- **Saptanga Theory of Kautilya** (state has seven limbs), given in the Arthashastra
  - **Raja**: king
  - **Janapada**: territory
  - **Kosha**: treasury
  - **Mitra**: allies / friends
  - **Amatya**: secretaries / ministers
  - **Durga**: fort
  - **Danda**: army

Q.29 Which of the following officials in the Mauryan administration was primarily responsible for supervising state agriculture and cultivation on crown lands?

[NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2025-26 (25 Mar, 2026 Shift 3)]

A. Aksapataladhyaksha
B. Sitadhyaksha
C. Panyadhyaksha
D. Samaharta

- **Samsthadhyaksha**: managed the market

- **Sitadhyaksha** = head of agriculture (state agriculture)
  - **Memory tip**: Sita Mata looks after agriculture
- Other officials
  - **Aksapataladhyaksha** (also called **Akshapatalika**): **Accountant General** (also called audit officer)
  - **Samaharta**: **Collector General of Revenue**
  - **Sannidhata**: **Chief Treasury Officer**

Q.30 By what name was the administrative head of the Mauryan city administration, as described in the Arthashastra, addressed?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (08 Sept, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Local
B. Regional
C. Nagarika
D. Gop

- **Nagarika** was the head of the city administration; he looked after the whole city
- **Gopa** was responsible for accounts

- **Other Mauryan officials**
- **Navadhyaksha**: superintendent of ships (Nav = boat)
- **Ashvadhyaksha**: superintendent of cavalry (Ashva = horse)
- **Shulkadhyaksha**: manages toll tax (Shulk = toll)
- **Yukta**: assessed revenue
- **Mahamatya**: senior administrative officer
- **Amatya**: administrative / executive official who assists the Mahamatya

Q.31 During the Mauryan period, the village headman in North India was known by _____.

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (03 Sept, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Gavunda
B. Gramika
C. Munda
D. Pattakila

- **Gramika** = village head

- **Mauryan taxes**
  - **Hiranya**: tax on gold
  - **Pranaya**: emergency tax
  - **Parshvam**: extra tax, like a surcharge today
  - **Senabhaktam**: army tax; a village through which the Mauryan army passed had to pay it

Q.32 Who were the 'Rajukas' during the Mauryan period?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (19 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Militias
B. Army administrators
C. Provincial officials
D. Craftsmen

- **Rajukas** were **provincial officials** (officials of the provinces)
- They were not army administrators, militia or craftsmen

Q.33 In Arthashastra, which two types of courts dealt with disputes among citizens and between the state and citizens?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (13 Jun, 2026 (4:30 PM - 6:00 PM))]

A. Sabha and Samiti
B. Mantriparishad and Parishad
C. Dharmasthiya and Kantakashodhana
D. Sangha and Gana

- **Kantaka Shodhana Nyayalaya**
  - Presided over by the **Pradeshta**
  - Dealt with **disputes between the state and the people** (a person's grievance against the state or administration)

- **Dharmasthiya Nyayalaya**
  - Presided over by the **Vyavaharika**
  - Dealt with **personal disputes among citizens**

Q.34 Which metal was extensively used for coinage in the Mauryan Empire?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (18 Jun, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Gold
B. Iron
C. Copper
D. Silver

- **Silver** was used the most for making coins in the Mauryan administration
- These were **punch-marked coins**
  - Started in the **Mahajanapada** period
  - Also called **Karshapana** (or **Karshapanaka**)
  - Punch-marked = symbols punched on the coin, such as the sun, mountains or an animal

- **Mauryan ports**
  - **Western:** Bharuch (present-day Gujarat), Sopara (present-day Maharashtra)
  - **Eastern:** Tamralipti

Q.35 After which battle did Ashoka embrace Buddhism?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (16 Jun, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Battle of Takshashila
B. Battle of Panipat
C. Battle of Taxila
D. Battle of Kalinga

- Ashoka adopted Buddhism after the **Kalinga War (261 BCE)**
- The war came **8 years** after his coronation
- He fought the Kalinga king **Ananta** (no need to memorise)
- After the war he replaced **Bherighosha** (conquest through war) with **Dhammaghosha** (conquest through Dhamma)
  - No more winning territory by war
  - He would spread the Buddhist philosophy and win the hearts of the people

- **Upagupta**: Ashoka's guru; with his help Ashoka sat on the throne (completed his coronation)
- Ashoka was the governor of **Ujjain** and **Takshashila** (if Ujjain is not in the options, tick Takshashila)
- Ashoka killed his brothers to take the throne
  - The tradition of "**99 brothers**" is an exaggerated number
  - Famous brother: **Susima**, the eldest
    - **Bindusara** wanted Susima to be the next king
  - Historical parallel: just as Shah Jahan always wanted his eldest son **Dara Shikoh** to sit on the throne, but **Aurangzeb** defeated and killed Dara Shikoh (in the Battles of **Dharmat** and **Samugarh**) along with his other brothers to take the throne, similarly Ashoka killed his brothers including the eldest, Susima

Q.36 Which inscription expresses Ashoka's remorse after the Kalinga war?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (13 Jun, 2026 (4:30 PM - 6:00 PM))]

A. Rock Edict I
B. Rock Edict VII
C. Pillar Edict V
D. Rock Edict XIII

- **Rock Edict XIII** shows Ashoka's deep remorse after the Kalinga War

- Ashoka's edicts: **14 Rock Edicts** (meaning 14 inscribed lines/statements) and **7 Pillar Edicts**
- **Important Rock Edicts**
  - **Rock Edict I**: stop animal slaughter / sacrifice
  - **Rock Edict IV**: Dhammaghosha gets priority over Bherighosha (no war, follow Dhamma)
  - **Rock Edict VII**: tolerance towards all religions
  - **Rock Edict XIII**: remorse after the Kalinga War

Q.37 What does 'Dhamma' primarily refer to in Ashoka's inscriptions?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (18 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Slogans of Buddha
B. Royal decree
C. Buddhist doctrine
D. Moral law

- Historical parallel: similarly, **Aurangzeb** compiled **Fatawa-e-Alamgiri**, which laid down moral laws and how Muslims should conduct their lives

- **Dhamma** in Ashoka's inscriptions = **moral law**

Q.38 What was the name given to the special officials appointed by Ashoka to spread his policy of Dhamma?

[NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2025-26 (25 Mar, 2026 Shift 2)]

A. Dhamma Lekhakas
B. Dhamma Mahamatta
C. Dhamma Janapada
D. Dhamma Mukhyas

- **Dhamma Mahamatta**: special officer appointed by Ashoka to propagate Dhamma
- Appointed separately from the usual Mauryan officers (such as **Sannidhata, Samaharta, Akshapatalika, Sitadhyaksha**, and **Samsthadhyaksha** who managed the market)

Q.39 Which Mauryan ruler sent Buddhist missionaries to foreign countries?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (12 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. Chandragupta II
B. Bindusara
C. Ashoka
D. Samprati

- **Ashoka** sent his son **Mahendra** and daughter **Sanghamitra** to **Sri Lanka (Ceylon)**
- Sri Lanka today follows the **Theravada** form of Buddhism
- They spread Theravada Buddhism there

Q.40 The inscriptions of Ashoka and Kharavela were primarily written in which of the following languages?

[NTPC UG CBT-01 2025-26 (08 May, 2026 (4:30 PM - 6:00 PM))]

A. Sanskrit
B. Pali
C. Bengali
D. Prakrit

- Ashoka's inscriptions were mainly in the **Prakrit** language
- Two types of inscriptions: **Rock Edicts** and **Pillar Edicts**
- **3 languages** and **4 scripts** were used
  - **Languages**: Prakrit, Greek, Aramaic
  - **Scripts**: Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek, Aramaic
- **Prakrit language** and **Brahmi script** were used the most

- **Where each was used**
  - **Brahmi**: all over North India
  - **Kharoshthi** (with Prakrit): north-western region (today's Pakistan, e.g. Peshawar)
  - **Greek script** (Greek language) and **Aramaic script** (Aramaic language): Afghanistan side
  - **Pillar Edicts** primarily in **Prakrit language** and **Brahmi**

Q.41 Who deciphered a Brahmi inscription referring king Ashoka as Devanampiya Piyadasi?

[NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2025-26 (19 Mar, 2026 Shift 3)]

A. R C Majumdar
B. Romila Thapar
C. James Princep
D. Susan Bayly

- **James Prinsep** deciphered the **Brahmi** script in **1837**
- Published in **1838**
- **Devanampiya Piyadasi** = "Beloved of the Gods"
- Before this, nobody knew a ruler named Ashoka existed

- Only a few inscriptions give Ashoka's actual name, **"Ashoka"** (Devanampiya Piyadasi Ashoka, not only Devanampiya Piyadasi)
  - **Maski** (Karnataka)
  - **Nittur** (Karnataka; also referred to as Andhra Pradesh in the lecture)
  - **Brahmagiri** (Karnataka)
  - **Gujarra** (Madhya Pradesh)
- Other inscriptions did not show whose they were

Q.42 Who discovered the Maski Ashoka Inscription?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (10 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. James Prinsep
B. C Beadon
C. Lord Canning
D. Christian Lassen

- **C. Beadon** discovered the **Maski** Ashoka inscription
- **Maski** is in **Karnataka**
- Do not confuse with **James Prinsep**, who first deciphered the script in **1837** (until 1837, it was not known that a ruler named Ashoka existed)

Q.43 Which of the following is true regarding the materials of construction used for Ashokan pillars?

[RRB NTPC Graduation CBT-01 2024 (23 Jun, 2025 Shift 3)]

A. They were largely made of stone.
B. They were largely made of wood.
C. They were largely made of concrete.
D. They were largely made of iron.

- Ashokan pillars were mostly made of **stone**
- **7 Pillar Edicts** does not mean 7 pillars; it means 7 lines / statements inscribed, and all of them were in **Prakrit language** and **Brahmi script**
- **Structure of a pillar (from bottom to top)**
  - **Shaft**
  - **Inverted lotus**
  - **Abacus** (cylindrical shape)
  - **Capital**: an animal figure on top

Q.44 The Lion Capital located at Sarnath, which is adopted as the national emblem of the Republic of India, was erected by which of the following Mauryan kings?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (08 Aug, 2025 Shift 1)]

A. Ashoka
B. Bindusara
C. Devavarman Maurya
D. Samprati Maurya

- **Ashoka** erected the **Lion Capital at Sarnath**; it is India's **national emblem**
- **Features of the Sarnath capital**
  - **Four lions** roaring, facing the four directions (East, West, North, South)
  - **Inverted lotus** at the base
  - **Abacus** (cylindrical shape) with animals separated by **Ashoka Chakras**
  - Animals: **elephant, bull, horse** (Note: the lecture transcript verbally mentions elephant, deer, horse; historically the abacus features elephant, bull, horse, and lion)
- Sarnath is also the site of the **Dhamek Stupa** and Buddha's first sermon **(Dhammachakra Pravartana)**

- **Rampurva pillar**
  - Capital: **bull**
  - The Rampurva bull is kept outside **Rashtrapati Bhavan** (President's House)
- **Lauriya Araraj (Bihar)**: no capital was found
- **Rummindei (Lumbini) Pillar Inscription (Nepal)**
  - Shows that Ashoka made the people of Lumbini **tax-free** when he visited
- **Nigali Sagar Inscription (Lumbini, Nepal)**
  - Shows that Ashoka enlarged the stupa of **Kanakamuni Buddha** when he visited

Q.45 During which period of Indian history were the stupas of Sanchi and Sarnath built, reflecting its architectural style?

[RRB NTPC UG CBT-01 2024 (29 Aug, 2025 Shift 2)]

A. Gupta rule
B. Kushan rule
C. Mauryan rule
D. Vakataka rule

- The stupas of **Sanchi** and **Sarnath** were built in the **Mauryan Empire**
- Mainly in the time of **Ashoka**



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